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Clean animals (Deut 14:4–6)

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2.1 Clean animals (Deut 14:4–6)

In DEU 14:4–DEU 14:6 there is a list of clean animals which contains three domestic animals, about which there is no difference of opinion, and seven other vegetation-eating animals, about which there is considerable difference of opinion.

It seems useful, before trying to identify each, to try to deduce from the archeological evidence which animals of this type would have been familiar to the people of the period. It is certain that they would have known the gazelle, the oryx, the ibex, the fallow deer, and the mountain sheep, since all of these were found in the region. These animals can be related to the Hebrew words tsvi, te'o, 'aqo, 'ayal, and zemer respectively. That accounts for five of the seven. The remaining two are a problem.

Among the wild animals found in biblical lands from very early times which would certainly have been considered clean are the red hartebeest and an antelope of the kobus type. It seems likely that the problematic Hebrew word yachmur refers to one of these, probably the hartebeest. If this is correct, then it would seem that Solomon kept herds of red hartebeest in later times in Israel (1KI 4:23). This type of herding of wild hartebeest was common in Mesopotamia and Egypt.

The other problematic Hebrew word, dishon, may refer to the kobus antelope, or to the addax antelope, which was another animal kept in herds in Egypt.

What is clear is that all "game animals" known to the Israelites — deer, antelopes, gazelles, wild goats, and wild sheep — were included in the list of clean animals. Retaining this fact in the translation is probably more important than establishing the identity of each of the Hebrew words.

Deuteronomy 14.4–5

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Hebrew	***shor***	***kesev***	***‘ez***	***’ayal***	***tsvi***
KJV	**ox**	**sheep**	**goat**	**hart**	**roebuck**
RSV	**ox**	**sheep**	**goat**	**hart**	**gazelle**
NEB	**ox**	**sheep**	**goat**	**buck**	**gazelle**
JB, NIV	**ox**	**sheep**	**goat**	**deer**	**gazelle**
TEV	**cattle**	**sheep**	**goats**	**deer**	**—**
NAB	**ox**	**sheep**	**goat**	**red deer**	**gazelle**
ERH	**cattle**	**sheep**	**goats**	**deer**	**gazelle**

Hebrew	***yachmur***	***’aqo***	***dishon***	***te’o***	***zomer***
KJV	**fallow deer**	**wild goat**	**pygarg**	**wild ox**	**chamois**
RSV	**roebuck**	**wild goat**	**ibex**	**antelope**	**mountain sheep**
NEB	**roebuck**	**wild goat**	**white-tailed deer**	**long-horned antelope**	**rock goat**
JB	**roebuck**	**ibex**	**antelope**	**oryx**	**mountain sheep**
NIV	**roe deer**	**wild goat**	**antelope**	**oryx**	**mountain sheep**
TEV	**—**	**wild goats**	**antelopes**	**—**	**wild sheep**
NAB	**roe deer**	**ibex**	**addax**	**oryx**	**mountain sheep**
ERH	**hartebeest (bubal)**	**ibex**	**antelope**	**oryx**	**mountain sheep**

Hebrew	shor	kesev	‘ez	’ayal	tsvi
KJV	ox	sheep	goat	hart	roebuck
RSV	ox	sheep	goat	hart	gazelle
NEB	ox	sheep	goat	buck	gazelle
JB, NIV	ox	sheep	goat	deer	gazelle
TEV	cattle	sheep	goats	deer	——
NAB	ox	sheep	goat	red deer	gazelle
ERH	cattle	sheep	goats	deer	gazelle
Hebrew	yachmur	’aqo	dishon	te’o	zomer
KJV	fallow deer	wild goat	pygarg	wild ox	chamois
RSV	roebuck	wild goat	ibex	antelope	mountain sheep
NEB	roebuck	wild goat	white-tailed deer	long-horned antelope	rock goat
JB	roebuck	ibex	antelope	oryx	mountain sheep

Deuteronomy 14.4–5

NIV	roe deer	wild goat	antelope	oryx	mountain sheep
TEV	——	wild goats	antelopes	——	wild sheep
NAB	roe deer	ibex	addax	oryx	mountain sheep
ERH	hartebeest(bubal)	ibex	antelope	oryx	mountain sheep